

Radio Svoboda Interview Concerning Stalinist-Like Denunciation of My Book “The Russia-Ukraine War and its Origins” (Full Text)

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Andreas Umland, Anton Shekhovtsov, and their ilk resort to a Stalinist-like denunciation of my open access book “The Russia-Ukraine War and its Origins.” They have no decency left. They want not only to censor my book but also to go after my university job, research funding, and subject me to criminal persecution and sanctions because they are incapable of challenging my evidence-based analysis. Instead of following standard academic norms and practices, they resort to such collective denunciation of a book and a Ukrainian and Canadian scholar. This is typical of Soviet practices and not of the Western academia. And their denunciation is based on primitive fraud, fakes, and slander.

It’s revealing who joined such Stalinist-like denunciation by means of false claims. For them, politics trumps merit, evidence, and scientific research. There are already those who express regret signing the collective denunciation of me and my book. They said that they did not read my book, trusted Umland’s solicitation and want now to withdraw their signatures. Like they said in the Soviet Union in collective denunciations of the “Doctor Zhivago” book, “I did not read it, but I condemn it.”

More than 120 people, including over 70 scholars from more than dozen countries, such as the US, the UK, France, Germany, Canada, Ukraine, Netherlands, Italy, Ireland, Norway, Spain, Japan, Poland, Romania, Georgia, China, Bangladesh, and South Africa, signed [Open Letter in Support of Academic Freedom and Ivan Katchanovski](#) just in two and half days.

The letter with the list of initial signatures is available at the following link https://docs.google.com/document/d/1Dv5ee5OK_MutZeXGIRyHBZ-REyEH0zOB-MnCjjaV0Uo/ It is open for signing by sending to openletter2026@gmail.com the name, position/job title, institutional affiliation, country, and if prefer that the name is not published and only institutional affiliation and country are listed.

This open letter was signed by prominent Western and Ukrainian scholars researching the Ukraine-Russia war and related topics in Ukraine and Russia. But the large number of signatures over such short time from scholars from different disciplines and people in other occupations from about two dozen countries shows that impact of my book and my other studies is not limited to the narrow field of East European area studies. This is also another demonstration that the claim that the popularity of my book is covertly engineered by Elon Musk using X is patently false.

Umland's initial draft, which he wrote was formulated with the involvement of Shekhovtsov, was sent to the large number of his handpicked recipients on January 1, 2026, but the absolute majority of them did not sign. He spent more than 4 months on personally soliciting signatures via email and added the denunciation of Elon Musk, whose Starlink has been critical for communication of the Ukrainian Armed Forces during the Russia-Ukraine war. I was forwarded copies of the different drafts of the Umland's denunciation and his solicitation emails.

Many scholars, including prominent Western and Ukrainian academics, criticized on the social media and in private messages to me this Umland-initiated collective denunciation. They called it on the social media as follows: '[neither democratic nor liberal nor properly academic, conspiratorial and obscurantist collective denunciation](#);' '[public lynching](#);' '[bullying mob](#);' '[KGB-style sabbath](#);' '[censorship and the inquisition](#);' '[bizarre letter laced with ad hominem attacks and conspiratorial thinking](#);' '[unfair, unbalanced, virtual gang assault](#);' '[a defamation campaign](#);' '[ad hominem attacks](#);' '[a self-discreditation of the signatories as scientists](#);' '[pseudo-academic mobilization to suppress politically unwelcome research](#);' '[useless and corrupted with agendas](#);' '[character assassination](#);' '[smears and censorship](#);' etc. Several journalists used similar terms, such as '[academic mob's coordinated attack](#);' '[war propagandists](#);' and '[a cesspool of pro-war grift](#).'

My book was published by a major Western academic press following very positive peer-review by two experts. It was endorsed by four leading American, British, and Ukrainian experts: Dr. Volodymyr Ishchenko, research associate at the Institute for East European Studies, Freie Universität Berlin; Dr Anatol Lieven, Director, Eurasia Program, Quincy Institute for Responsible Statecraft; Richard Sakwa, Emeritus Professor of Russian and European Politics, University of Kent, UK; and Jack F. Matlock, Jr, Duke University and the former US ambassador to the Soviet Union. Jack Matlock called this book "absolutely essential reading for anyone who wishes to understand why the war in Ukraine occurred and why it is vital for Ukraine to agree to a negotiated settlement."

In her [review](#) of my open access book, a noted British journalist wrote that "The Russia-Ukraine War and its Origins is not just another study of the conflict. It is a tour de force of advocacy—for truth—a feat of evidence gathering and probably the closest that anyone has come to disentangling the host of conflicting narratives that have so characterised this war."

Umland and co in their denunciation deliberately misrepresented findings of my book which clearly [states](#):

The analysis shows that the illegal Russian invasion of Ukraine on February 24, 2022, represented the extreme escalation by Russia of the conflicts with Ukraine and the West, the civil war in Donbas, the annexation of Crimea, and the Western-backed violent and illegal overthrow of the pro-Russian government in Ukraine by the oligarchic and far-right alliance by means of the Maidan massacre and assassination attempts during Euromaidan. NATO accession of Ukraine was a major factor, but it, like the role of the far right, was inflated by Russia. Russian imperialism was also significant but secondary factor. Ukraine is not a democracy.

My book shows that narratives propagated by the Russian governments and media concerning the Russia-Ukraine war and its origins are false. It shows that contrary to Russian government and media propaganda the Russian invasion in 2022 was illegal under the international law, that this is a war and not a special military operation in Ukraine. My book also shows that there is no genocide of ethnic Russians/ Russian speakers in Donbas, that the war crimes are primarily committed by the Russian forces, that the killings in Bucha and the MH17 shutdown were not false flags by the Ukrainian forces/Western-organized provocation, that there is no Nazi or neo-Nazi regime in Ukraine, there was no ‘fascist coup’ in Ukraine in 2014, that Ukraine is not a US colony, that there were covert Russian military interventions in Donbas in August 2014 and January 2015, and that the Russian annexation in Crimea is illegal.

My book specifically shows that the Russian government and propaganda justification of the war by threats of imminent NATO accession of Ukraine and US missiles deployment, the Nazi regime in Ukraine, and a preventative special military operation to stop Ukrainian attack in Donbas, and humanitarian intervention to stop genocide in Donbas are false. It shows that Russian imperialism was a major factor, in particular, in the annexation of Crimea, Donbas, and Kherson and Zaporizhzhia regions, but that there is no evidence that Russia wants to occupy and annex entire Ukraine.

The Russian role in the war origins is not confined to Russian imperialism. My book examines many factors of the war origins. Denying role of other factors and claiming that Russian imperialism was the only factor of the war origins and any scholar who does not accept it and deviates from it echoes Russian propaganda has nothing to do with science and academic research. This is an attempt to force scholars to follow not evidence but propaganda, narrative control, and political agenda.

Various other books by scholars focused on the role of the West in the war origins. They include Stephen Kinzer’s “Boiling Point: How America Brought War to Ukraine, Scott Horton in Provoked: How Washington Started the New Cold War with Russia and the Catastrophe in Ukraine.” He is Senior Fellow at the Watson School of International and Public Affairs at Brown University and the former The New York Times correspondent. Such arguments are also made by the University of Cambridge Emeritus Professor Jonathan Haslam in his book “Hubris: The American origins of Russia’s war against Ukraine” that was published in 2025 by Harvard University Press. Other such books include Benjamin Abelow’s “How the West brought war to Ukraine: Understanding how U.S. and NATO policies led to crisis, war, and the risk of nuclear catastrophe;” and “The Russo-Ukrainian War: Follies of Empire” by Richard Sakwa.

The collective denunciation offers only one specific example challenging my book’s specific findings, which show that the Russian annexation of Crimea in February-March 2014 was “mainly a disproportionate escalation of the conflict as a reaction to the Western-backed violent overthrow of the pro-Russian government in Ukraine during Euromaidan.” But my [book](#), along with various other evidence, specifically quotes US President Barak Obama who [stated](#) in his CNN interview in 2015 that “Mr. Putin made this decision around Crimea and Ukraine, not because of some grand strategy, but essentially because he was caught off balance by the protests

in the Maidan, and Yanukovych then fleeing after we'd brokered a deal to transition power in Ukraine."

My [book chapter](#) about the war origins quotes statement by Donald Trump in the All-In Podcast with David Sacks that the NATO accession of Ukraine provoked the Russia-Ukraine war. It quotes NATO Secretary General Jens Stoltenberg that Putin "went to war to prevent NATO, more NATO, close to his borders." It quotes Davyd Arakhamia, the head of the Ukrainian delegation at the peace talks that the Ukrainian neutrality was main Russian condition for the peace deal and that the war could have ended in spring of 2022 if Ukraine had agreed to neutrality.

My book also quotes Ursula von der Leyen, the EU Commission President, that the Maidan massacre was crucial in the origins of the Russia-Ukraine war. She stated that "this conflict began already ten years ago," "when peaceful protesters, just waving the European flags in Maidan Square, were shot dead by snipers." Such major Western media as the [New York Times](#) and [CBC](#) also linked Euromaidan, and specifically, the Maidan massacre with the roots of the Russia-Ukraine war.

In essence, the collective denunciation letter falsely accuses not only the book by a Ukrainian and Canadian scholar but also Obama, Trump, NATO and EU chiefs, the head of Zelensky faction in the parliament and the head the Ukrainian delegation at peace talks, the New York Times, CBC, and many others of echoing Russian propaganda on the war origins. They also falsely accuse Elon Musk and David Sacks, two leading American entrepreneurs and members of the US administration, of echoing Russian propaganda because they supported the GoFundMe crowdfunding to make my book open access, i.e. freely accessible.

They falsely link me and my book to the Russian media simply because a US-educated German professor at a Turkish university, who specializes in Ukrainian history, was one of those who congratulated me on X with its publication. I do not give any Russian media interviews during the war. There were no Russian media publications citing my book "The Russia-Ukraine War and its Origins." I publicly condemned the Russian invasion of Ukraine from the start in my Ukrainian and Western media interviews and on the social media.

My book is based not on Russian, Ukrainian, or Western propaganda but on thousands of primary and secondary Ukrainian and Western sources. In contrast to me, Umland, Shekhovtsov, and those who signed their denunciation with just a few exceptions did not publish books about the Russia-Ukraine war. Einstein reportedly said in response to the publication of the German book "100 Authors Against Einstein": "Why 100? If I were wrong, one would have been enough" to disprove his theory of relativity. Scientific truth is based on verifiable evidence and not on political denunciations and numbers of those who denounce it.

Ukrainska Pravda propagates such defamation, denunciations, and fake news concerning me. I helped to publicize in the US media kidnapping and killing of its founder by helping an American journalist to travel to Ukraine and cover this story.

The collective denunciation letter propagates primitive fakes about popularity of my book, because it reached 248,000 views and downloads on the publisher website 6 months since its official publication. It falsely claims that Musk and Sacks covertly promote its views and downloads on X. Like their Soviet counterparts denouncing books, which they did not read, they did not even read the book's preface or read it but propagated deliberate fraud, nevertheless. My book clearly [states](#):

My academic publications, which primarily concern conflicts and politics in Ukraine, have reached over 2,000,000 reads and downloads just on my academic websites and the publisher sites. My research-based Twitter and Facebook posts and YouTube videos reached over 125,000,000 views. I am one of the most cited political scientists who specialize primarily in politics and conflicts in Ukraine. My research-based publications, interviews, and comments appeared in more than 4,000 media reports in more than 80 countries. They include such major Western media as ABC News, BBC Ukrainian, Associated Press, Canadian Press, CBC News, CTV News, France 24, France Télévisions, Daily Beast, Euronews, Global TV, Globe and Mail, Guardian, Hill TV, La Presse, Le Figaro, La Razón, La Stampa, National Post, Reuters, Sky News Australia, Times Higher Education, Vice, and Washington Post.

My [paper](#), "The "Snipers' Massacre" on the Maidan in Ukraine," is the [most downloaded](#) paper among almost 20,000 papers on subject of 'Ukraine' in Academia.edu, a major registered-based research depository and site for scholars. I published its greatly expanded and updated versions and parts in peer-reviewed [journals](#) and [books](#). These open access studies have over 1,000,000 views and downloads. Four my papers are among the top dozen [most downloaded](#) papers on subject of 'Ukraine' on Academia.edu. Umland, Shekhovtsov, and their ilk are well aware about impact of my previous studies, but they deliberately propagate fakes.

It's revealing that the Umland-led denunciation deliberately omits my open access book "[The Maidan Massacre in Ukraine: The Mass Killing that Changed the World](#)" and its nearly 500,000 views/downloads just on the publisher website. The denunciation letter even falsely claims that Yanukovych was not removed from presidency during Euromaidan. Colleagues said that Umland told them privately even before the war that he was convinced by my studies of the Maidan massacre. His 2018 [Facebook post](#) suggests this as well: "Worrying collection of testimonies collected by Ivan Katchanovski. Given the ambivalence of this evidence, the snipers massacre demands a proper investigation and extensive report. That such a document does not yet exist is, unfortunately, a worrying sign by itself."

But instead of admitting this publicly he and his ilk resort to Stalinist-like denunciation of me and my other book "The Russia-Ukraine War and its Origins: From the Maidan to the Ukraine War" and false claims that its 248,000 views/downloads were covertly engineered by Elon Musk.

My Maidan massacre book, 4 peer-reviewed journal articles and 2 book chapters, including in a chapter in "The Russia-Ukraine War and its Origins," about this massacre are based on testimonies by the absolute majority of wounded Maidan protesters and about 100 witnesses for the Maidan massacre trial and investigation in Ukraine, testimonies by over 500 other witnesses

and 14 self-admitted Maidan snipers, over 20 videos of such snipers, ballistic and medical examinations by Ukrainian government forensic experts, bullet hole locations, and synchronized videos of the massacre. Major findings of my studies are de facto corroborated by the text of two verdicts of Ukrainian courts. The Ukrainian media and the mainstream Western media, with a few notable exceptions, did not report such evidence even though it is available online in my academic and social media publications video appendixes of my book and peer-reviewed journal articles.

Unreported parts of the nearly [1,000,000-word](#) Maidan massacre trial verdict that was issued by the Sviatoshyn District Court in Kyiv in October 2023 following a seven-year long trial of 5 Berkut police officers [confirmed](#) findings of the studies that many Maidan activists were killed and wounded and BBC and ARD TV journalists were shot at not by Berkut or other law enforcement but by snipers in the Hotel Ukraina and other Maidan-controlled locations. It also confirmed findings of my studies that this hotel was “activists-controlled” and that there was a far-right-linked special armed Maidan company in this hotel and the Music Conservatory. The verdict stated there were no Russian snipers involved in the massacre and that there were no massacre orders by Yanukovych, his government, the SBU, and the Ministry of Internal Affairs. The trial verdict stated that Maidan then was not a peaceful protest but “a rebellion” which involved the massacre of the Berkut and other police members.

The declassified text of the Ukrainian [court verdict](#) in March 2025 confirmed the false flag shooting of Maidan activists in Khmelnytskyi during the Maidan massacre. Forensic expert examination of videos, forensic ballistic and medical examinations, on-site investigative experiments by government forensic experts, witness testimonies, and investigations by the SBU the Ukrainian Military Prosecutor Office showed that gunshots made from the SBU veranda, which was occupied by Maidan activists, killed elderly female Maidan protester and wounded other Maidan protesters. The verdict acquitted the ex-head of Khmelnytskyi SBU and the SBU Alfa officer for shooting of these Maidan activists because of the lack of evidence of their involvement in the shooting and because of such evidence of the false flag shooting.

Oleh Tatarov, who is now the deputy head of the Zelensky Office of President of Ukraine, told Western ambassadors on February 19, 2014 that Maidan protesters were shot in the back by other Maidan activists and that the police did not shoot them. Tatarov, who then was the deputy head of the investigative department of the Ministry of Internal Affairs, was the first to publicly refer to the false flag Maidan massacre one day before 49 Maidan activists and 4 police officers were killed in the false flag mass killing.

Calling the false flag Maidan massacre and testimonies by the Maidan protesters and other Ukrainian witnesses, and verdicts of the Ukrainian courts Russian propaganda is therefore Orwellian propaganda itself.

Open-access publication of my book was funded by open access publication grant from the University of Ottawa and over [360 GoFundMe](#) contributors. Contrary to the denunciation, Elon Musk did not fund my book but helped on Twitter/X to unblock my GoFundMe for this book.

I publicly thanked Elon Musk, David Sacks, and all contributors, whom Umland, Shekhovtsov and their ilk slander. It is great that that such leading US Silicon Valley entrepreneurs openly supported crowdfunding for an academic book and opposed the attempt of political censorship.

Umland falsely [calls](#) Elon Musk and David Sacks “techno-fascists” and now [states](#) that “the purpose of the ‘campaign is to counteract interventions by super-rich techno-authoritarians with connections to the White House in Eastern European studies.” He and other denouncers, who came from the said institutions, are perfectly fine with Firtash, a Ukrainian oligarch wanted by the US on bribing charges, giving \$6.7 million to establish and finance Cambridge Ukrainian Studies; Pinchuk financing Ukrainian history initiative, and over 1,000,000 endowments by SS Galicia Division veterans for the Canadian Institute of Ukrainian Studies.

Andreas Umland in recommendation section, [approvingly quoted](#) a call for total mobilization in Ukraine by a neo-Nazi [admirer of Hitler](#), and called videos of forced mobilization in Ukraine Russian propaganda. He propagated the now discredited conspiracy theory about the [false flag](#) Nord Stream bombing by Russia. Anton Shekhovtsov [headed](#) the Dugin's far-right organization in Crimea and led its protest against NATO in Ukraine. Umland, Shekhovtsov, and their ilk try to force scholars to parrot such propaganda and propagate politically convenient fake narratives that they propagate themselves.

Umland and Shekhovtsov resorted to such denunciation in retaliation of [references in my book](#) to their partisan whitewashing of neo-Nazis in Ukraine:

Some researchers, especially from partisan think tanks, regarded the role of the far-right organizations and formations in Ukraine in Euromaidan, and the war in Donbas as insignificant or marginal. They focused on numerical strength of far-right organizations and electoral support for the far-right parties and ignored or denied the far-right involvement in political violence, such as the Odesa massacre and the civil war in Donbas. They claimed that the presence of Russian-speakers in the Azov regiment and other neo-Nazi-led armed formations is evidence of their relative tolerance and asserted that the Azov regiment moderated by abandoning its far-right roots (see, for example, Umland, 2019, 2020)...Anton Shekhovtsov compared the mass killing of people by a fire in the Trade Union building in Odesa to his killing of Colorado potato beetles by collecting them in a box and then burning them” (Anton, 2014). He was earlier a leader of the Crimean branch of the pro-Russian far-right Eurasian Youth Union led by Aleksandr Dugin (AntiNATOvskii, 2006).

The denunciation of me and my scholarly book by Umland, Shekhovtsov, and their ilk is not only an open attack on academic freedom but also an attempt to censor my book and subject me to criminal prosecution or sanctions for my academic research. They falsely link my book to Russian propaganda, Russian media, and “apologetics” of the Russian invasion, which are all criminal offenses in Ukraine. There were many such cases of political persecution in Ukraine.

My house, land, and all other property in my native Western Ukraine were illegally seized in retaliation of my scholarly studies of the Maidan massacre in Ukraine. I was blacklisted on the Ukrainian government-linked Myrotvorets hit list for “crimes” of showing involvement of

radical nationalists and neo-Nazis in this massacre of the Maidan protesters and the police and for exposing the SS Galicia division veteran, who was given standing ovations in the Canadian parliament by the Canadian government, parliament, Zelensky, and his delegation. The Ukrainian government agency, led by the leader of the OUN, which collaborated with Nazi Germany and was involved in organizing the SS Galicia Division, banned my book and threatened me with criminal prosecution for it.

Their Stalinist-era predecessors published in a Ukrainian newspaper a similar denunciation of Mykhailo Krawtchouk, my distant relative, and his mathematical book, during the Stalin's Great Terror. Two volumes of this mathematical book were [translated and used](#) by the American inventor of the electronic digital computer in inventing his computer to speed up solutions of mathematical equations by methods that this noted Ukrainian mathematician developed. He was then arrested on false charges and perished in Stalin's GULAG. Now, their contemporary successors use this invention for similar political denunciation of me and my academic book.